

Early Islamic design

The Umayyads (r.661–750) were the first Islamic rulers to found a dynasty, and their magnificent buildings were designed to project authority, combining elements of Byzantine and Sassanid Persian architecture. Establishing their court at Damascus, they built a series of grand palaces.

The Great Mosque (opposite, 705–15), modelled on the prototype of the Prophet's mosque in Mecca, featured a vast enclosed courtyard with a minaret at each corner, and a central prayer hall divided by Corinthian columns into three aisles. Drawing on Christian architectural features, it included domes, round arches, Byzantine-style gold mosaics, carved reliefs and veined marble slabs. The Great Mosque at Samarra (851) is noted for its spiralling minaret, the 52-metre (162-ft) Malwiya Tower, as well as early Islamic decoration in the form of floral and geometric stucco carvings. The Great Mosque of Córdoba, built in 785 under the Abbasid caliphate (750–1513), marked the beginnings of Moorish architecture in the Iberian peninsula.

